

United Nations Environment Programme

Thomas Jefferson Model United Nations Conference

TechMUN XXXIII



High School General Assembly

Co-Chairs: Goutam Kanakadandi & Nikhil Kanchinadam

Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology

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Dear Delegates,

It is with immense pleasure that we welcome you all to TechMUN XXXIII and the United Nations Environment Programme. We are both sophomores at TJ and are elated to be working with all of you in this upcoming committee. We are excited for a weekend of debate on some of UNEP's biggest issues: *Weaponization of Environmental Policy in Global Trade* and *Preserving Ecosystems from Artificial Intelligence Infrastructure and Urbanization*. Each of you will be representing a country, and we hope to be able to see those countries reflected through your solutions. In particular, this committee will aim to delve into certain international issues threatening our world's future.

This weekend we are looking for delegates with innovative ideas and detailed solutions to present and hope that every one of you will have a strong presence in committee to ensure debate is constantly flowing. As co-chairs, the dias would like to see eloquent, substance-filled speeches, along with exceptional leadership, teamwork, and diplomacy. While the committee is a place of debate, it is of utmost importance to be considerate and respectful of other delegates. We hope that every one of you step out of your comfort zone this weekend, whether it be through giving speeches without notepads or branching out more in unmods. Most importantly, don't give up at any point, no matter what happens. One small mess-up isn't the end of the world and as your chairs, we understand that committee can be nerve-wracking, so don't be afraid to make mistakes and try new things. Whether this is your first conference or you are a seasoned delegate, we hope to make this iteration of TechMUN as fun as possible! If you have any questions, please feel free to email uneptechmun2026@gmail.com.

Goutam Kanakadandi & Nikhil Kanchinadam

Co-Chairs, United Nations Environment Programme

Topic A: Weaponization of Environmental Policy in Global Trade

Introduction:

Environmental policies have slowly become an increasingly more important part of global trade as countries look to address the issue of climate change, pollution, and resource depletion. Enforceable measures such as carbon taxes, emissions standards, deforestation regulations, and sustainability requirements are used and brought into legislation very frequently to promote environmentally responsible produce and consumption. Theoretically, these policies help protect the planet while encouraging greener economic practices at the same time. On an international level, it supports climate goals such as the Paris Agreement.

However, environmental policies have the potential to be used strategically as tools of economic and political leverage in global trade. When countries set strict environmental standards on imports or place systems such as carbon border taxes, these policies become trade barriers for developing countries. These countries don't have the financial nor the technological ability to meet high environmental standards, so they are consistently affected very harshly, raising concerns regarding the fact that environmental protection is being used as a front to justify economic pressure and protectionism.

As environmental issues and trade continue to become more interconnected, the ability of these environmental policies to become "weapons" becomes a grand challenge for the international community. Balancing legitimate environmental objectives with fair and inclusive trade systems is extremely crucial to prevent eco-friendly and green policies from deepening global inequalities or escalating trade disputes.

Current Situation:

In recent times, multiple major economies have proposed or implemented environmental trade measures to some extent, such as carbon border adjustment mechanisms(CBAMs), bands on products that are commonly linked to deforestation, and stricter sustainability requirements. While these policies intend to reduce the amount of carbon leakage in the atmosphere and incentivize cleaner production, they have unintentionally sparked tensions between developed and developing nations. Many developing countries now argue that such measures place unfair limitations on exporters and limit the country's access to global markets.

Yet, at the same time, there is no globally agreed-upon framework within the international trade system to properly and accurately differentiate between truly environmental regulation and protectionism undercover. The World Trade Organization(WTO) allows for some environmental exceptions, but conflict accross the world are increasing based on WTO's interpretation of this difference, further expanding the issue of trade conflicts and decreasing the trust in trade institutions.

Possible Solutions:

To properly address the weaponization of environmental policy in global trade, it's extremely important that international coordination and proper cooperation are implemented to establish clear and consistent rules. Strengthening cooperation between environmental agreements and trade-based organizations like the WTO can help to fully make sure that environmental measures are based on science and are proportional to the issue at hand, while not inciting conflict with developing nations. Providing clear guidelines for this can reduce the misuse of environmental policies as trade barriers.

Supporting developing countries is extremely important as well, as financial support, the spread of technology, and initiatives made to help exporters meet environmental standards could

truly help while making sure that economic growth isn't sacrificed for anyone. Effective collaboration between developed and developing countries will assist in the promotion of an egalitarian transition to green trade practices while making sure that environmental protection doesn't become a tool for economic exclusion.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can the international community distinguish between genuine environmental protection and disguised trade protectionism?
2. What role should the WTO play in regulating environmentally motivated trade measures?
3. What role should the WTO play in regulating environmentally motivated trade measures?
4. Should there be global standards for environmental policies that affect international trade?

Helpful Links:

- <https://www.un.org/en/climatechange>
- <https://www.oecd.org/trade/environment.html>
- <https://www.unep.org/topics/finance-and-economic-transformations>

Topic B: Preserving Ecosystems from Artificial Intelligence Infrastructure and Urbanization

Introduction:

With the development of technology advancing at faster rates than ever before, new practices and uses are becoming more common. Artificial intelligence (AI) is a transformative piece of technology that has been experimented with and can generate new content in mere seconds. AI can transform the construction of infrastructure and urbanization, as AI-driven tools, among other digital tools, are much quicker and provide easy access to available information. AI infrastructure and urbanization offer advantages, such as technological connectivity and increased efficiency in data management. They can also be used to monitor ecosystems, ecological conditions, predict environmental changes, and optimize energy usage, given that artificial intelligence is implemented in the correct way. Although AI can improve efficiency and innovation in these areas, it has raised concerns about habitat disruption and land degradation, meaning it is essential to balance AI development with ecosystem preservation.

AI urbanization entirely depends on constructing infrastructure and expanding urban landscapes, which begins to conflict with natural habitats and ecosystems. An increase in technology can contribute to deforestation, water scarcity, and biodiversity loss, making it much harder to restore environments to their original form before urbanization. Producing, maintaining, and operating AI infrastructure also requires and uses a large amount of energy, primarily gained through nonrenewable sources, which increases the risk of climate change from excess carbon and greenhouse emissions. As of now, 2 to 3% of the Earth's total land is covered by urban areas, and by 2030, this number is expected to grow by over 100,000 square miles.

As AI and urbanization become increasingly prevalent, addressing these environmental concerns and maximizing benefits are essential to ensure sustainable ecosystems, reduce climate change, and maintain life in both water and on land, all lining up with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) 11, 13, 14, and 15.

Current Situation:

In many developing regions and low-income countries, environmental regulations struggle to keep pace with the rapid growth of AI, making it very difficult to mitigate environmental effects. By 2030, data centers and AI could emit more than 40 million metric tons of carbon dioxide annually, rapidly increasing the risk of climate change and global warming. This can erode habitats on both land and in water. Additionally, AI infrastructure needs vast amounts of energy, placing more strain on already limited natural resources. Without international frameworks, balancing technological progress with ecosystem preservation continues to remain a significant challenge.

Possible Solutions:

Addressing both the challenges and opportunities of AI infrastructure and urbanization requires a multi-faceted approach. Nation governments need to implement clear policies on land consumption and construction of infrastructure while maximizing the benefits AI provides. Investing in new methods of habitat preservation can help lessen the overall effect of climate change and urbanization, and public awareness campaigns can help educate the public on this pressing issue. These efforts, among others, can ensure ecosystems are preserved in the midst of urbanization.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can governments implement environmental regulations that ensure AI infrastructure development does not damage surrounding ecosystems?
2. What strategies can be used to reduce the carbon, energy, and water footprint of data centers and AI technologies?
3. How can renewable energy sources be prioritized and integrated into AI infrastructure to minimize environmental damage?
4. In what ways can urban planning integrate AI development while preserving biodiversity and natural habitats?
5. How can companies be held accountable for the long-term environmental impacts of AI-driven urban expansion?

Helpful Links:

- <https://sdgs.un.org/goals>
- <https://www.unep.org/news-and-stories/story/ai-has-environmental-problem-heres-what-world-can-do-about>
- <https://medium.com/urban-ai/data-centers-and-the-environmental-footprint-of-artificial-intelligence-what-cities-can-do-now-0b043a8feb28>
- <https://news.mit.edu/2025/explained-generative-ai-environmental-impact-0117>

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Land Policy, 23 Oct. 2025,

www.lincolninst.edu/publications/land-lines-magazine/articles/land-water-impacts-data-centers/.

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